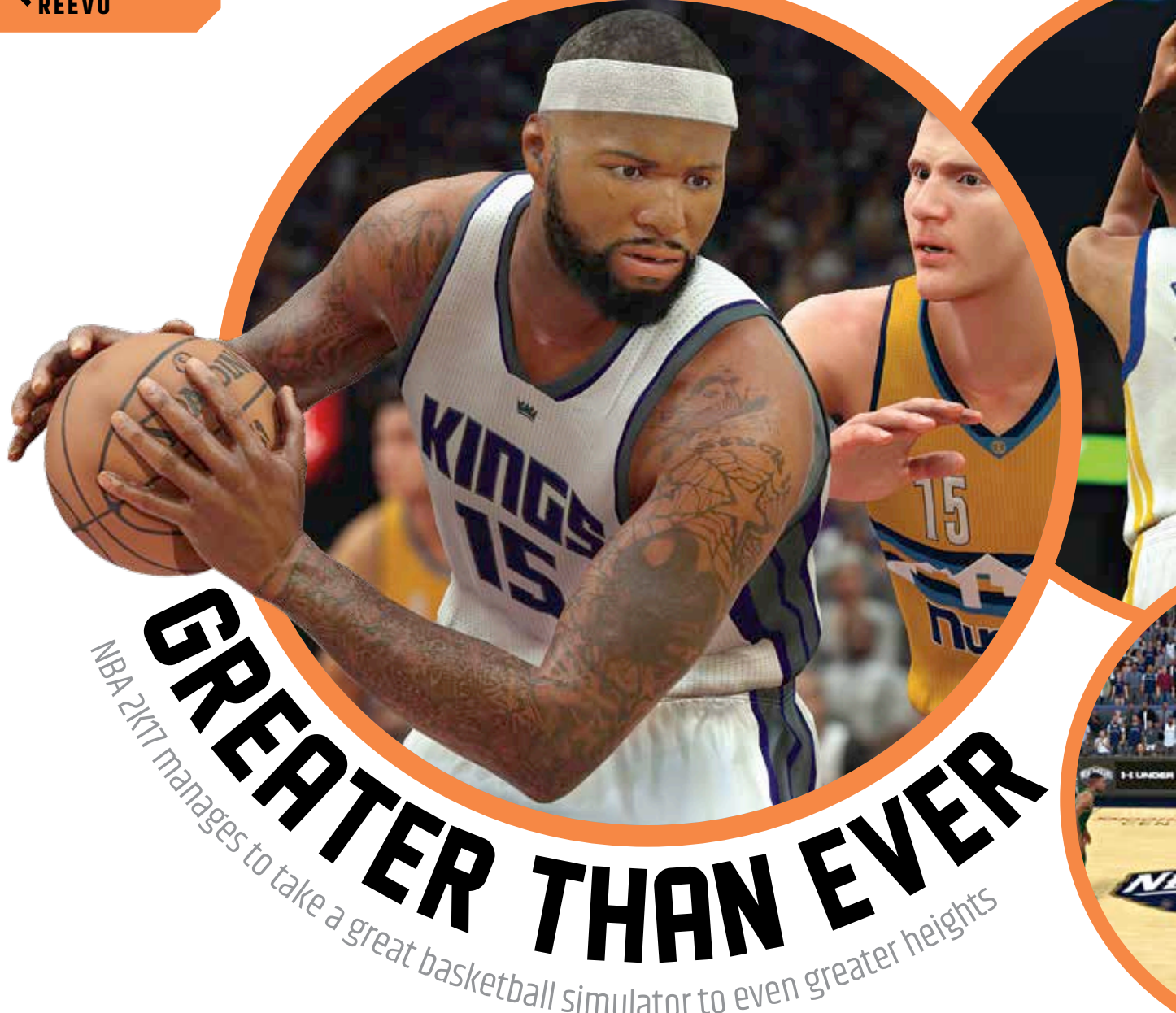




GREATER THAN EVER

NBA 2K17 manages to take a great basketball simulator to even greater heights

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had a difficult job with this game, their annual basketball sim. Last year's installment – NBA 2K16 – was a runaway hit, adored by critics and gamers alike. The stakes were unusually high for this year's release to not drop the ball. That's like the virtual equivalent of Chicago Bulls replacing Michael Jordan in his last season with LeBron James at the peak of his game, or Manchester United

drafting in Pep Guardiola to take over from the legendary Alex Ferguson. That's one helluva task. But the good guys working on NBA 2K17 must be gifted geniuses because they managed to pull off the unthinkable! It's nothing short of a miracle but pure basketball bliss.

Compared to NBA 2K16 last year, 2K17 feels even more fluidic and dynamic. The controls have been tweaked by just a smidge to make it more intuitive and indicative than last year, and this makes all the difference while playing the game. For instance, now there's a

semicircle under the player you're controlling to indicate the right time to release and throw the ball. Ball-related actions performed as the semicircle turns green ensures the best possible result – for the most part. Fail to execute a properly timed shot (which is when the circle turns green) and you have to see it horribly go wide or bounce off the rim – not a pretty sight. This visual aid single-handedly makes a big difference for newcomers entering the franchise for the very first time. Very quickly, you get a sense of timing with not only shot-making, but dribbling, mak-

